

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in an online magazine:

Why was Super Mario a plumber?



In 1985, a little Italian plumber became the face of video games, and changed the way we play them. 'Super Mario Bros' featured the main character in the game, Mario, jumping around collecting coins and rushing to save Princess Peach from a villainous turtle.

At the time, video games were usually created by computer engineers, as opposed to today's artists.

"I was trying to use the technology available at the time to produce a distinctive-looking character from a small number of pixels, and that resulted in Mario," said Shigeru Miyamoto, the game designer and producer of Super Mario Bros. As to why he picked a 26-year-old Italian-American plumber from New York as the main character, Miyamoto said, "We wanted him to be someone who might live near you, and not a superhero."



"People had never seen a game like Super Mario Bros," said Frank Cifaldi, co-director of the Video Game History Foundation, "Super Mario Bros manages to convey an epic adventure in a massive world. Day turns to night as you progress. You cross bridges into new lands." Super Mario Bros changed the way we play video games – "from merely aiming for a high score to playing a game to experience an adventure and see it through to its ending," he said.

To celebrate Super Mario's 40th anniversary, Nintendo has launched Mario-centred games. These new games use nostalgia for Mario and other classic games while experimenting with recent technologies like augmented reality.

Your group is preparing a class project about video games. You may want to talk about:

- why people still play classic games like Super Mario Bros
- what makes a video game popular for a long time
- what video games will be like in the future
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you play video games?
2. What kind of video games do you like?
3. Do you prefer games with ordinary characters or superheroes?
4. Do adults like playing the same video games as young people?
5. Would you like to be a game developer?
6. Are all video games suitable for children to play?
7. Do you agree that video games can be works of art?
8. How do video games influence young people?